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Praise the Imperfect



To speak ill of the dead is one of the few privileges of journalism. To go unabashedly panegyric at the first rush of sorrow, too, is a routine instinct of journalism. Somewhere in between lies the cool, dispassionate gaze—and that too you get once in a while from journalism. The assassination of Benazir Bhutto has brought out, in varying degrees, all three. Now, in the mounting post-assassination punditry, the first and third, I'm afraid, are becoming one. Any realistic assessment of the slain, it seems in this confluence of what pretends to be skepticism and what aspires to be detachment, has to be unsentimental about her less than glorious record as a politician and a prime minister. So, the argument goes, get real before canonising the irredeemably flawed democrat. Flawed perhaps is not the word. Corrupt. Autocratic. Paranoid.

Dynastic. Inefficient. And more. Who set the stage for Taliban next door? Didn't she too, like any other Pakistani ruler, let the ISI do the dirty work for her? Wasn't it the evil she helped create that finally did her in? Well, if Pakistan today is the safest home to the enemies of civilisation, wasn't Benazir too responsible? She was dispensable. The postmortem by a section of the commentariat has been none too charitable.

The corollary to this argument is: it's worth mollycoddling Musharraf, for he is made possible by worthless democrats like Benazir. That's why Musharraf's coup was treated as a necessary transgression by those who were fed up with the discredited civilian rulers. Even now, the Musharraf fan club outside Pakistan is quite influential—it includes the President of America. The dictator sets the limits of Pakistan's democracy, and the world's most powerful democracy—and its most idealistic presidency so far—is okay with it. What Pakistan needs is more of Benazir, no matter how imperfect or discredited a democrat she was. The tragedy of Pakistan is that it has never been given a chance to punish an imperfect democrat democratically. A discredited Bhutto or Nawaz Sharif should be replaced by a slightly better one. Let flawed democracy play out its script uninterrupted, and through sheer trial and error there will emerge something more legitimate than Musharraf. That only a strongman can build the nation, sell happiness and ensure stability is a fallacy prevalent in places like Islamabad and Moscow. An idiosyncratic chess player or a less reputable civilian is better than a Putin or a Musharraf—if that's what democracy offers.



Photograph by: BANDEEP SINGH

PURUSHOTTAM DIWAKAR



TWO'S COMPANY: Mathur (left) and Raje

Playing Along

JAIPUR Chief Minister Vasundhara Raje and her dissidents couldn't seem to make up their minds on who to appoint as the state party president. Their woes were put to rest by BJP president Rajnath Singh who removed Mahesh Sharma and installed Om Mathur at the helm of the state party while Raje was holidaying on New Year's eve. She had earlier favoured Mathur who has been credited with leading BJP to victory in the state assembly polls. But she did a volte face and decided to go with Sharma.

Mathur is known for being assertive and ambitious—his name was once floated for chief minister-ship—and is also capable of creating trouble, as he did with former chief minister Bhairon Singh Shekhawat. Raje first wanted to allay her apprehensions about Mathur before his appointment.

She now denies that she was ever against Mathur. Knowing well that he has to work with Raje for the party, Mathur said that she would lead the party to victory and would continue as chief minister.

by Rohit Parihar

Currency Crisis

SRINAGAR PDP's neo-separatist policies in Jammu & Kashmir to appease voters have apparently touched a nadir. PDP leader and finance minister in the coalition government, Tariq Hameed Karra, has said that the state can have a separate currency after achieving "self rule", the agenda pursued by the PDP to counter the National Conference's autonomy plank. Congress spokesman Abhishek

Singhvi slammed the separate currency issue as "irresponsible and unviable". "It is totally contrary to all constitutional principles, norms and conventions. We strongly refute it." But Karra claims that "Prime Minister Manmohan Singh and Sonia Gandhi have said that there should be a common currency for South Asia; so let us start from Kashmir."

by Aljaz Hussain